

HABACUC

THE PROPHECY OF HABACUC.

PREFACE.

Habacuc was a native of Bezocher, and prophesied in Juda some time before the invasion of the Chaldeans, which he foretold. He lived to see this prophecy fulfilled, and for many years after, according to the general opinion, which supposes him to be the same that was brought by the angel to Daniel, in Babylon. Dan. xvi. Ch. --- He might very well live to see the captives return, as only sixty-six years elapsed from the first of Joakim, when he began to prophesy, till that event. He retired at the approach of the Chaldees, and afterwards employed himself in agricultural pursuits. C. --- The sins of Juda, the coming of the Chaldees, and the relaxation of the captivity are specified; and in the canticle, the appearance of Christ, the last judgment and eternity, (W.) are mentioned in the most sublime style. H.

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CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. Burden. Such prophecies more especially are called burdens, as threaten grievous evils and punishments. Ch. --- He says not against whom, because the menace is directed to persecutors in general. W.

Ver. 2. Save. Some think that he expresses the sentiments of the weak, like David, (Ps. lxxii. 2.) or what he had formerly entertained. The language of the prophets is very bold. Ex. xxxii. 32.

Job iii. 3. Jer. xx. 14. Jon. iv. 8. C.

Ver. 3. Opposition. Sept. "the judge receives" bribes. H. --- Such was the state of Juda after Josias. Jer. xxi. 12.

Ver. 5. Among. Sept. ye despisers. S. Paul nearly agrees with this version. Acts xiii. 41. The copies vary, as the Heb. has done. C. --- The

apostle gives the mystical sense; the literal is very obscure. W. --- God answers the prophet's complaints, and shews that the Chaldees shall punish the guilty, and afterwards be themselves chastised.

Ver. 6. Chaldeans. Nabuchodonosor was the first of this nation who attacked Joakim, and having conquered all as far as the Nile, returned to succeed Nabopolassar. He afterwards came upon Jechonias and Sedecias, &c. The prophet might have all this in view, particularly the first invasion. C. --- Bitter; warlike, as all the Gr. historians remark. S. Jer. --- The Chaldees were not yet arrived at such greatness, and of course this is not the Habacuc specified Dan.

xiv. W. --- Yet the same prophet might foresee it. H.

Ver. 7. Proceed. They admit no authority but their own. C. --- This pride will prove their ruin.

H.

Ver. 8. Leopards: the swiftest quadrupeds. C. --- The horses near the Euphrates were swift and warlike. Oppian. --- Swifter. Heb. "sharper" (H.) in seeing, even when there is no moon. Elian x.

26. --- Evening. Sept. "Arabian." H. --- It may denote the hyena of that country, which is most terrible. Guevar.

Ver. 9. Burning. Heb. also, "eastern," which is hot, and raises the sand of Arabia so as to be very detrimental. C. --- Out of 2,000 travellers from Mecca to Aleppo, only twenty-nine escaped such a storm, or kamsin, in that vast desert, Aug. 23, 1813. Rock. 312. H. --- Sand, from various countries. Is. xx. 4. Beros.

cited c. Ap. i.

Ver. 10. Prince, or "it," the nation. v. 10. Heb. "They," &c. --- Laughingstock, (ridicule.) Nabuchodonosor raised or deposed princes as in jest. H. ---

Sennacherib's officers were or had been kings. Is. x. 8. --- Mount. Thus cities were chiefly taken. Ezech. iv. 1. C.

Ver. 11. Spirit; viz. the spirit of the king of Babylon. It alludes to the judgment of God upon Nabuchodonosor, recorded Dan. iv. and to the speedy fall of the Chaldean empire. Ch. --- It shall yield to the Medes, &c. after conquering the Assyrians. W. --- Fall. Heb. "sin." Sept. "obtain pardon." --- God: "idol." Chal.

"This is the strength of my God." Sept. God forced the proud king to confess that his great exploits were not to be attributed to himself or to idols. H.

Ver. 12. Die? We hope that this scourge will not entirely ruin us. --- Correction, like Pharaoh.

Ex. ix. 16.

Ver. 13. Look, with approbation (C.) or connivance.

Ver. 14. Ruler. People are subdued by Nabuchodonosor. H. --- They make little resistance. C.

Ver. 16. Drag, adoring his own arms and prowess, (Sanct.) like Mezentius and Capaneus: *Dextra mihi Deus*, (*Æn.* x.)

Te voco, te solum, superum contemptor, adoro. Stat. x.

--- Guevare thinks fishes were adored, as they were among the Syrians.

Nabuchodonosor attributed all to his own genius, or to Bel, whose statue he set up. Dan. iii. C. --- Victorious nations thus honour themselves and not God.

Ver. 17. Nations, of every country. W. --- Few have been so much addicted to war as Nabuchodonosor. C.

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CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Will stand, &c. Waiting to see what the Lord will answer to my complaint, viz. that the Chaldeans, who are worse than the Jews, and who attribute all their success to their own strength, or to their idols, should nevertheless prevail over the people of the Lord. The Lord's answer is, that the prophet must wait with patience and faith; that all should be set right in due time; and the enemies of God and his people punished according to their deserts. Ch. --- The prophet speaks, waiting for a further revelation, (W.) not seeing before the reasons of Providence in permitting the wicked to prosper.

H. Ps. lxxii. 17. --- He is informed that the kings of Babylon, (v. 5. 8.) Juda, (v.

11) Tyre, (v. 14) and Egypt, (v. 18) and all who trust in idols, shall suffer. v. 19.

Hereupon the judgments of God are pronounced just. C. --- Tower. Aq. &c.

"circle." The ancient Jews say Habacuc formed a circle, out of which he would not stir till he was satisfied, (Kimchi) as Popilius did. V. Max. vi. 4. Dan. xi. 29.

C.

Ver. 2. Over it. It shall be so legible (H.) anyone may hear or take a copy. C.

Ver. 3. Slack. That which happens at the time fixed is not. W. --- Heb. "the vision is for an appointed time." Habacuc might live to see the conquest and downfall of Nabuchodonosor.

Many think that the first and second coming of Christ (Heb. x. 36. Rom. i. 17.) are here insinuated, as the dominion of the aforesaid king represented the slavery of mankind under the devil, and the liberty granted by Cyrus was a type of their redemption. The felicity of the

Jews is the last event which the prophet specifies, and this is here the literal sense. S. Cyr. C.

Ver. 4. Unbelieving. Prot. "lifted up." H. --- The king's vain projects shall fail.

Sept. Rom. "If he withdraw himself, my soul shall not have pleasure in him. But my just man shall live by my faith." Others read with S. Paul, "my just man shall live by faith." Heb. x. 38. C. --- The source of content arises from faith, (without which this life would be a sort of death, as the apostle and S.

Aug. Trin. xiv. 12. &c. observe) because it is the beginning of life by grace, which the works of the law could not otherwise confer. Gal. iii. W. --- The Heb.

will admit the sense of the Sept. and we ought rather to shew this in passages which the authors of the New Testament quote, than to excuse them. Here their version seems preferable to that given by moderns, ecce elata est, non recta anima ejus in eo, the drift of which who can guess? Beza has acted unfairly,

"at si quis se subduxerit non est gratum animo meo;" whereas the text speaks of the "just man," as Theophylactus observes. "Hence all who know his theological opinions, may see how suspicious his translation must be accounted." Pearson. pref. Sept. H.

Ver. 5. As wine deceiveth, &c. viz. by affording only a short passing pleasure, followed by the evils and disgrace that are the usual consequences of drunkenness: so shall it be with the proud enemies of the people of God, whose success affordeth them only a momentary pleasure, followed by innumerable and everlasting evils. Ch. --- Heb. "but as the proud man prevaricates in wine, he shall not succeed." Baltassar's reign was short. Vat.

De Dieu. --- Nabuchodonosor saw himself reduced to the meanest condition.

--- Hell. He is insatiable. Prov. xxx. 16. C. --- Æstuat infelix (Alex.)
augusto limite mundi. Juv. x.

Ver. 6. Parable. Lit. "marvel," or wonderful speech; parabolam. ---
Dark. Prot. "a taunting proverb;" (H.) when Nabuchodonosor became
like a beast, and his empire was soon after divided.

C. --- Clay. Ill-gotten goods, that like mire both burden and defile the
soul. Ch.

--- Gold and silver are only a sort of earth. Job xxvi. 16. Zac. ix. 2.
Habacuc does not even name riches, out of contempt. Some think (C.)
that he alludes to the grave. People prayed for their deceased friend:
Sit tibi terra levis. Drus.

Ver. 7. Bile, like worms in the grave. Cyrus will overturn the kingdom.
The Rabbins pretend that Evilmerodac caused his father's body to be
cut in pieces for the crows, lest he should return again. C.

Ver. 8. Blood. For cruelty, avarice, &c. the Chaldees shall be ruined. W.
--- City, different from that land of the Arabs, who dwell under tents.
This city may denote Jerusalem, Babylon, &c.

Ver. 9. Wo. This is commonly understood of Nabuchodonosor; but it
seems rather to designate Joakim, (Jer. xxii. 13.) whose injustice
scandalized the prophet. C.

Ver. 10. House. Thinking to establish thy family for ever, thou hast
proved its ruin by avarice,

&c. W. --- This is applied to Nabuchodonosor, but may be as well
explained of Joakim, who oppressed his people, and was cast out like
an ass. C.

Ver. 11. Timber. Heb. " caphis (Sept. the insect kantharos) from the
wood shall answer." H. ---

The signification of the Heb. term is unknown. It was customary to place beams of wood after some courses of stone, to strengthen the building. 3 K. vi.

36. C. --- The crimes were so crying, that if men were silent the very stones would publish them. M.

Ver. 12. Wo. This might be explained of Nabuchodonosor; but we rather understand the king of Tyre, whose pride was intolerable. Ezech. xxviii. It seems useless to repeat so often the same threats against one king. C.

Ver. 13. Things, &c. That is, shall not these punishments that are here recorded come from the Lord upon him that is guilty of such crimes? Ch. or, are not these riches from the Lord? The king of Tyre thought himself a god. Ezech.

xxviii. 2. C. --- People; enemies of God's people. Ch.

--- The riches of the Tyrians shall perish, so that the troops of Nabuchodonosor shall find nothing worth their trouble. Thus all were justly punished.

Ver. 14. Sea. The land and naval forces attacked Tyre. C. --- Vast multitudes came against Babylon. M. --- The punishment of the wicked will cause many to adore and to fear the Lord. H.

Ver. 15. Wo. All this may refer to the king of Egypt, who deceived Joakim, Sedecias, &c. C. ---

Sept. "O, he who giveth drink to his neighbour, a cruel overthrow, and who maketh," &c. ---

Nakedness. Sept. "caverns;" deluding him, so that his places of retreat become useless. H. ---

The Jews relate that Sedecias was intoxicated, and then acted with indecency.

S. Jer. --- But these accounts deserve little credit.

Ver. 16. Glory. Egypt shall suffer at last. Is. xix. 14. Jer. xliii. &c. It was customary to hand the cup about. Jer. xxv. 17. Mat. xxvi. 27. C.

Ver. 17. Libanus. That is, the iniquity committed by the Chaldees against the temple of God, signified here by the name of Libanus. Ch. -- - Egypt had persuaded the governor of Cœlosyria and the Jews to revolt, and then abandoned them. --- Beasts, which were adored in Egypt. Those who explain all of the Chaldees are much perplexed, understanding the army of Cyrus, or the oppressed nations, or subjects to be meant. C. --- And of. Heb. "land of the city," as v. 8.

Ver. 18. Thing, Prot. falsely, "image." H. --- This is addressed to all idolaters.

Ver. 20. Temple. Heb. "palace," or heaven. House is generally put for the temple. --- Silence, out of respect, &c. The guards of the eastern princes observe the utmost silence and modesty. God is very different from idols. He is the arbiter of life and death. C. --- Silence often denotes subjection. 1 Mac. i.

3. M.

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CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. For ignorances. That is, for the sins of his people. In the Hebrew it is shignoth: which some take to signify a musical instrument, or tune, with which this sublime prayer and canticle was to be sung. Ch. --- The term is omitted in several Latin MSS. The precise import cannot be ascertained; yet it seems to imply a song of comfort. C. --- Sept. "with a canticle." H. --- S.

Jerom follows Aq. Sym. and the 5. edit. Theodot. has, "for voluntary"

transgressions. C. --- All sins proceed in some degree from ignorance, (W.) and are all the effects of free-will. H. --- The prophet prays to be freed from sin, and foretells the coming of Christ, &c. W. --- The :Fathers apply this canticle to Him, as the Church herself does in her office. We cannot go astray, following such guides. Yet some think that an allusion is made to the return from captivity, and from Egypt, which were noble figures of the world's redemption.

The prophet concludes with adoring the ways of God, (C.) which at first he had not comprehended. H. --- He is astonished at God's mercy, in becoming incarnate for man's sake. W.

Ver. 2. Thy hearing, &c. That is, thy oracles, the great and wonderful things thou hast revealed to me: and I was struck with a reverential fear and awe. Ch.

--- I saw that the unjust would not escape. C. --- Work. The great work of the redemption of man, which thou wilt bring to life and light in the midst of the years, when our calamities and miseries shall be at their height. Ch. ---

Years, at the time appointed. W. --- Sept. read, "Lord, I considered thy works, and was astonished; in the midst of two living creatures, or lives, thou shalt be known," (H.) or found, between an ox and an ass, as the Church has it. Nat.

and and Circumc. W. --- Christ appeared when the world was most dissolute.

M. --- The tradition of two animals being near the crib where he was born, is not of earlier date than about the fifth century. Some explain this of the Father between the Son and the Holy Ghost; others of Christ between the thieves, or the two testaments, or collecting his Church from Jews and Gentiles, &c.

Sanct. C. --- Moderns agree with S.

Jerom's version. The prophet begs that God would perform his ancient miracles in his days, (C.) by relieving the captives, as he had formerly delivered their ancestors. H. --- Make. Heb. and Sept. "when the years approach, thou shalt be made known; when the time shall come, thou shalt be manifested; when my soul shall be troubled, in wrath thou," &c. H. --- God never shuts the gate of mercy to the penitent. Nah. i. 3. C.

Ver. 3. South. God himself will come to give us his law, and to conduct us into the true land of promise: as heretofore he came from the south, (in the Heb.

Teman) and from Mount Pharan, to give his law to his people in the desert. See Deut. xxxiii. 2. Ch. --- Sept. render, "the shady and thick mount, Diapsalma." S.

Jerom, Pharan semper. Heb. Sela. Ps. ix. W. --- The term seems to denote a pause. There might be many in the same canticle, (C.) as we find three here, (v.

9. 13) and many placed at irregular distances in the Psalms. H. --- The Hebrews had long sojourned in the Stony Arabia, under the guidance of the Lord. We should render in the past time to v. 16. C.

--- Christ was born (H.) at Bethlehem, to the south of Jerusalem, (W.) and had given the law, as a Jew interpreted this passage to S. Jerom. He was probably a convert. H.

Ver. 4. Horns, &c. That is, strength and power, which by a Heb. phrase are called horns: or beams of light, which come forth from his hands: or it may allude to the cross, in the horns of which the hands of Christ were fastened, where his strength was hidden, by which he overcame the world, and drove out death and the devil. Ch. --- Horns may also designate the nails, the prints of which remained in our Saviour's hands after his glorious resurrection. H. ---

God appeared hurling his thunderbolts (v. 11. Ps. xvii. 16. C.) with a fiery law in his right hand, all shining with glory. Ex. xix. 18. and xxxiv.

29. Deut. v. 22. H. ---

Sinai seemed to be all on fire.

Nothing can resist lightning. C. --- Fulmine terres. Æn. i. --- Hid, Sept. "and he has placed the strong love of his power," (H.) Jesus Christ, who has given his life for us. C.

Ver. 5. Death, &c. Both death and the devil shall be the executioners of his justice against his enemies; as they were heretofore against the Egyptians and Chanaanites. Ch. --- Heb. daber, (H.) according to the different pronounciation, is rendered "the word" by the Sept. and Theo.; "the plague," by Aquila, &c.

After Christ was baptized, the devil came to tempt him. S. Jer. --- Devil.

Heb. resheph, (H.) or "bird," (Sym. &c.) means "creeping on the belly," as is explained by the Jews of the devil, who tempted our first parents. S. Jer. ---

Moderns (H.) follow the Chal. and understand the carbuncle. C. --- Prot.

"burning coals:" marg. "diseases," (H.) resembling the pestilence. God destroyed his enemies and the murmuring Hebrews. C. --- Sept. "and it (the word) shall go out into the fields behind his feet." God's will shall be published in the field of the world, (H.) when the gospel shall be preached to the Gentiles.

Ver. 6. Measured. Sept. "the earth was troubled," C. or shaken. H. --- He beheld.

One look of his eye is enough to melt all the nations, and to reduce them to nothing. For all heaven and earth disappear when they come before his light.

Apoc. xx. 11. Ch. --- The Chanaanites were dismayed at the approach of God's people. He routed the nations, and determined the portion

which he had chosen for Israel. Jos. ii. 9. C. --- Mountains. By the mountains and hills are signified the great ones of the world, that persecute the Church, whose power was quickly crushed by the Almighty. Ch. --- The roughest roads in the wilderness were made smooth. God is poetically described at the head of his people. Deut. viii. 4. and xxxiii. 15. Ps. lxxv. 5. C.

Ver. 7. Ethiopia, the land of the Blacks, and Madian, are here taken for the enemies of God and his people, who shall perish for their iniquity. Ch. --- Chus peopled that part of Arabia. H. ---

Heb. has Chusan, perhaps to rhyme with Madian; though some think that Chusan (defeated by Othniel) and Madian (over whom Gedeon gained a complete victory) are designated, Judges ii and vi. When the Hebrews had crossed the Red Sea, the Arabs and Madianites removed their tents in great trepidation. C. --- These nations dwelt chiefly under tents, or skins, which would be removed in time of war. W.

Ver. 8. With the rivers, &c. He alludes to the wonders wrought heretofore by the Lord in favour of his people Israel, when the waters of the rivers, viz. of Arnon and Jordan, and of the Red Sea, retired before their face; when he came as it were with his horses and chariots to save them; when he took up his bow for their defence, in consequence of the oath he had made to their tribes; when the mountains trembled, and the deep stood with its waves raised up in a heap, as with hands lifted up to heaven; when the sun and moon stood still at his command, &c. to comply with his anger, not against the rivers and sea, but against the enemies of his people. How much more will he do in favour of his Son, and against the enemies of his Church! Ch. --- Horses: the ark of the covenant. C.

Ver. 9. Take. Sept. bend thy bow over the sceptres, says the Lord, Dinpsalma."

Sela is neglected by the Vulg. or (H.) by S. Jerome, as having no meaning. C.

--- Yet we find in the edition of his works he renders it, for ever; and here observes, that the Lord "always dwells with his saints,"

and attacks vices by their mouths. --- Rivers. Sept. "the earth shall be cut by rivers." H. --- Greek historians mention several rivers which have appeared or ceased to flow in consequence of earthquakes. The apostles, moved by Christ, water the world and form the Church. S. Jer.

Ver. 10. Grieved. They seemed full of surprise, as in labour, (Heb.) and the abyss spoke in its manner, (C.) obeying thy voice, and letting the Israelites pass. H. Ps. lxxiii. 15. and cxiii. 3.

Num. xxi. 13. C. --- "Earth, sea, and rocks quake at the sight of God." Æschyl.

H. --- Sept. are obscure, (C.) "Peoples shall behold thee, and grieve, (or be in labour: odinehsousi has both meanings. S. Jer.) dividing the waters of the passage, the abyss," &c. Other cop. read, "Thou, Lord, wilt divide," which S.

Jerome explains of heresies, which soon disappear. H.

Ver. 11. Go. The five kings shall flee at the descent of Bethoron; or the heavenly body shall proceed at thy command, at the signal given by thunder.

Jos. x. 11.

Ver. 13. Christ. This may well be explained of the incarnation. God was touched at the miseries of his people, and rescued them by Moses. C. --- Theodotion and Symmachus, "Ebionite, half Christians," give a Jewish interpretation, "to save thy Christ." Aquila, though a Jew, and the 5th edit. agree with us; but the 6th edit. best explains the mystery, "through Jesus, thy Christ." S. Jer.

--- Head, &c. Such was Pharaoh heretofore; such shall antichrist be hereafter.

Ch. --- It may also be understood of Nabuchodonosor and of all persecutors. H.

--- Cyrus cut off Baltassar; Christ will destroy antichrist, (2 Thess. ii. M.) the head of the wicked congregation. Is. xi. 4. W. ---

Neck, or root. Pharaoh's eldest son perished. Ex. xiv. 17. C.

Ver. 14. Sceptres. The nobles were drowned (H.) with their king, (C.) when they expected an easy prey. Ex. xiii. 9. H. --- Heb. "thou hast pierced the chief of their troops in the midst of tribes," or sticks, as the Egyptians perhaps slew each other. C.

Ver. 15. Sea, &c. to deliver thy people from the Egyptian bondage; and thou shalt work the like wonders, in the spiritual way, to rescue the children of thy Church from their enemies. Ch. ---

The waters stood up like mountains, while God seemed to pass in his triumphal car. C.

Ver. 16. I have heard, &c. viz. the evils that are now coming upon the Israelites for their sins; and that shall come hereafter upon all impenitent sinners: and the foresight that I have of these miseries makes me willing to die, that I may be at rest, before this general tribulation comes, in which all good things shall be withdrawn from the wicked. Ch. --- The five woes denounced C.

ii. make the deepest impression upon me. H. --- I fear lest I should sin. S. Jer.

--- The thought of so many wonders makes me speechless. C. --- Me. Let me find rest in the grave, like Job. H. ---

I trust that God will raise me up. C. --- Heb. "rottenness hath entered,...and I trembled in myself."

Sept. (15) "horses, troubling many waters: (16) I watched, and my belly was filled with fear at the voice of the prayer of my lips, and trembling

entered my bones, and under me my strength (or frame, exis; some read ischus) was troubled. I shall rest in the day of my tribulation, to go up to the people of my parish," or neighbourhood; paroikias. H. --- People, &c. That I may join the happy company in the bosom of Abraham, that are girded; that is, prepared for their journey, by which they shall attend their Lord, when he shall ascend into heaven. To which high and happy place, my Jesus, that is, my Saviour, the great conqueror of death and hell, shall one day conduct me rejoicing and singing psalms of praise. v. 18. and 19. Ch. --- Girded. Heb.

"transmigration or desolation." Habacuc was mercifully allowed by Providence to dwell in Juda, when almost all were led away. He was transported through the air to feed Daniel, (xiv. 32.) where he might see his brethren, as he here insinuates, having relied on God's mercy. v. 2. C. --- Prot. "when he cometh up unto the people, he will invade them with his troops; (marg. "cut them in pieces") 17.

Although the," &c. When all shall be ravaged, I will still hope. H. --- All must be patiently endured, that we may rest at last. W.

Ver. 17. Fail. Lit. "lie," (H.) or frustrate our expectations. C. --- Spem mentita seges. Hor. i. ep.

7. --- Fold. Sept. "food."

Ver. 18. Jesus. Heb. yishi, "my (H.) salvation." C. --- Sept. "saviour." Chal.

"redeemer." H. ---

Jesus was the desire of all nations, and he imparts true joy to the faithful. John viii. 56. C. --- At the last day, plagues similar to those of Egypt will occur; but the elect shall rejoice. S. Jer.

Ver. 19. Places. I shall escape the fury of the Chaldeans, and sing a hymn of thanksgiving. C.

--- "The conqueror singing psalms" may be unconnected with the rest, (H.) and designed to shew that the hymn was intended for religious

meetings. It may signify, "To the chief over the female musicians." C. --
- Lamnatseach binginothai. Prot. "to the chief singer on my stringed
instruments." Marg.

"Neginoth." Sept. "He will order my feet unto perfection. He will
establish me upon the heights, to gain the victory in his canticle." H. ---
I shall exchange my former complaints for songs of praise, and be
crowned by Jesus. S. Jer.